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What skills will the next generation of business leaders require, especially with data and machine intelligence shaping business decisions?

I believe data-related learning is largely domain-specific and useful at the entry level. However, the kind of students we prepare for leadership roles in large organisations requires a stronger conceptual framework.

They need not only the ability to interpret data but also the ability to understand what the data means and how it can be used for larger strategic decision-making with a long-term impact.

This conceptual strength is what gives longevity to management professionals. We are moving towards a world where specialised skills will continue to change rapidly. Therefore, the ability to think deeply, understand problems and create sustainable solutions will remain critical.

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One finding from the Business Today survey this year is the changing student mix — with the share of engineers declining and non-engineers increasing. What does this shift mean? We have also seen female participation decline after years of growth. Is this a temporary trend or does it indicate a larger change?

If the number of engineering students is declining across institutions, one possible reason could be the volatility in the job market. Today, many technology professionals are uncertain about future roles and opportunities and therefore may prefer to continue in their existing jobs rather than pursue further education immediately.

The changing technology environment, including AI, is also influencing career decisions.

However, at institutions like IIM Calcutta, diversity has always been a priority. We give additional weightage to non-engineering backgrounds because we do not want the institution to be dominated by a single academic discipline.

This has been a conscious effort, and many leading IIMs follow a similar approach.

On female participation, the data for IIM Calcutta does not indicate a decline. In our MBA programme, female participation was 28% in 2025-26, and it has increased to 36% this year.

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On the job market situation you mentioned, can relatively muted pre-placement offers be seen as a sign of a broader slowdown in fresh hiring?

We cannot comment on what is happening at other institutions, but in our case, we have not seen a decline.

Our regular MBA programme has around 480 students. During internships, the number of pre placement offers stood at around 155 last year, which is over 30%. The number of opportunities has increased.

The conversion of these offers into pre-placement offers has also been better compared to previous years.

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Looking ahead, given all the changes taking place, what do you see as the future role, relevance and value of the management degree?

When we talk about management education, we need to recognise that students pursuing these programmes broadly fall into two categories.

The first category includes those who are preparing to meet the immediate requirements of organisations — with knowledge, skills, discipline and professional capabilities.

The second category includes those who are being groomed for larger leadership roles in organisations, and that is where the responsibility of institutes like IIM Calcutta becomes more important.

Our role is to develop individuals who can eventually take larger leadership responsibilities — not only for organisations but also for the country's development. BT

"Along with technology-focused learning, we are expanding flexible learning models. We are planning to start an online MBA programme"

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